

GIREESH G V



◀ **SIRI, ABHINAYA IN *RANGOLI*, is better known by the name of the character she plays in this Kannada daily serial.**

continue to inspire the female viewers of Sun TV, Zee Bangla and Zee Marathi, surpassing the popularity of the Hindi saas-bahu sagas. The TRPs of top grosser family dramas *Minnukettu*

in Malayalam and the Telugu *Chakra vaakam* fluctuate between 12 and 14 while *Ya Sukhano Ya* on Zee Marathi and *Khela* in Bangla hover around four.

So what makes these serials click? Middle-class family dramas with life-like characters and a generous dose of emotions seem to be the answer. "Bengal is open to any theme as long as it is thick with emotions. People find comfort in good emerging triumphant and evil being exposed," says Rajib Chatterjee, business head and senior vice-president, Zee Bangla.

Srinivasan believes Hindi soaps do

FAR FROM THE FLASHY

■ By Aditi Pai

It's 9 p.m. on a Wednesday evening in Chennai and the action has now moved indoors, in front of the television sets. Viewers are ready—with tissues in hand—to watch Abhinaya cope with family crises and clinch that all-so-important business deal in *Kolungal*, a Tamil soap. In the past three years, audiences have shared Abhinaya's journey—from that of a young divorcee to a successful businesswoman, striving in a male dominated society.

"People identify with her trials and tribulations, cry with her and rejoice for her," says B. Srinivasan, managing director of Vikatan Televistas (vt) that produces *Kolungal* and its Kannada remake *Rangoli*. vt, the production wing of the 80-year-old Vikatan Group, launched *Rangoli* on Udaya TV in July 2005, which rapidly overtook other programmes with TRPs at around 13.5. Going strong with over 920 episodes with the TRP touching

an astronomical 21 (higher than *Kyunki Saas Bhi Kabhi Bahu Thi...* at around 6.6), *Kolungal* at prime time on Sun TV certainly has its Tamil viewers hooked.

Where the hold of the Hindi-speaking national television ends, the realm of regional television begins. "Our audiences like stories where women protagonists emerge strong in the end. We portray a middle-class world and characters people can identify with," asserts S.J. Clement, vice-president of the Sun TV network, which has programmes that are topping the Tamil, Malayalam, Telugu and Kannada ratings.

So, while the Tulsis and the Parvatis of Hindi screens cope with kitchen politics and quibbling in-laws, the fiery Abhinaya, the young Teesta and the complacent Sarita

▶ **AISHWARYA MARKAR, SARITA IN *YA SUKHANO YA*, plays the demure Sarita and has now become a household name, thanks to her Marathi soaps.**

BHASKAR PAUL

